existence of essences is the view that causal relations are forms of conceptual construction and not objective realities. We formulate in the categories of cause and effect what seem to us regular associations. But this is a projection that suits human interests. Insight into emptiness is the realisation that there is no absolute conception of reality that is accessible to us. It is a mistake to draw a distinction between what is ultimately real and what is only conceptually real, and between absolute truth and conventional truth. The truth is that there is no ultimate reality. There is no difference between ***nirvana*** and ***samsara***.

Acceptance that there are no essences removes our need to invent and cling to ultimate truths, dogmatically held: an activity that reinforces our self-love.

Further reading: K. Bhattacharya 1998; Burton 1999; Garfield 1995; Lindtner 1982; Williams 1989

Skandhas: according to Buddhism the five components of personality, apart from which there is no further factor called Soul (***atman***). The components are: matter, sensation, habits, dispositions, thoughts and perceptions. They are always in a flux and human lives are processes belonging to a wider field of energies.

The five psychophysical components of personality are described as follows:

1. Form or corporeality (*rupa*): comprised of the four base elements, earth, water, fire and air and their derivatives which include the physical sense organs and their external objects.
2. Sensation or feeling (*vedana*): this may be physical or mental and is derived from contact between the six internal sense organs (five plus mind (***manas***) which relates to mental phenomena or thinkables (***dharma***))